RELEASE NOTES: 2020 SIPP

Revision History		
Date	**Change**	**Updated by**
10/28/21	Initial version	A. Smith
7/24/25	Updated version	J. Lee

Version 1.1 (Released 7/24/25)

On July 24, 2025, the U.S. Census Bureau released updated public-use files for the Survey of Income and Program Participation (SIPP) from 2014 through 2021.

Social Security Amount Correction

From 2014 through 2021, a processing error affected the creation of the monthly Social Security amount variable (TSSSAMT). The SIPP instrument asks about monthly Social Security payments before any Medicare deductions are taken out (gross amounts). However, a processing error added the values of Medicare Parts B, C, and D deductions (ESSPARTBKNOW, TSSPARTCAMT, and TSSPARTDAMT) to the initial Social Security reported amounts, meaning these deductions were double-counted. As a result, values of TSSSAMT were higher than they should have been. This error had downstream effects on income and poverty recodes. This issue was resolved in the 2022 SIPP.

To correct this issue, the Census Bureau removed the double-counting of the value of Medicare deductions.[1] It then re-applied disclosure avoidance procedures to the revised TSSSAMT variable and recreated the personal, family, and household income and poverty recode variables that depend on TSSSAMT as an input. For the 2014 files, these updates also included updating the disclosure avoidance procedure used on TSSSAMT to match the procedure used on subsequent SIPP files.

Minor Changes to the Income Recode Variables

The following minor errors were also corrected in the updated files:

- In the 2018-2020 SIPP, the Type 2 income of unrelated household members was missing in the calculation of total household income including Type 2 persons (THTOTINCT2).[2]
- In the 2014 Panel, total personal income (TPTOTINC) was equal to 0 rather than missing for those who were out of universe (e.g. children under age 15 who did not receive SSI payments).[3]
- In the 2014 Panel, the status flags for total family income (AFTOTINC), total household income (AHTOTINC), and total family income including Type 2 persons (AFTOTINCT2) sometimes had a

[1] Information regarding how to address the processing error in already downloaded data is available at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2022-usernotes/2022-prior-process-err-affct-soc-sec-self-amts.html>.

[2] More information about this error is available at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2020-usernotes/2020-thtotinct2-missing.html>.

[3] More information about this error is available at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2014-w4-usernotes/2014w4-tptotinc-aftotinc-ahtotinc-aftotinct2-errors.html>.

value of 0 (not in universe) or 8 (imputed using a combination of methods) rather than a value of 9 (recoded using other variables).[4]
- In the 2014 Panel, there were some instances in which total family income including Type 2 persons (TFTOTINCT2) was calculated incorrectly due to improper treatment of Type 2 income.[5]

There were some additional minor changes implemented in the 2014 panel to align the calculation of total family income including Type 2 persons (TFTOTINCT2) and total household income including Type 2 persons (THTOTINCT2) with the 2018 SIPP. The changes include:

- In the calculation of total family income including Type 2 persons (TFTOTINCT2),
    - Families are now consistently grouped by Type 2 family number (RFAMNUMT2) in all years.
    - Households are now only grouped by residence (ERESIDENCEID) in all years.
- Type 2 income is no longer rounded before being added to total family/household income including Type 2 persons (TFTOTINCT2/THTOTINCT2).
- Status flag values for total family/household income including Type 2 persons (AFTOTINCT2/AHTOTINCT2) now allow for a value of 3, which indicates the value was logically assigned for cases in which total family/household income comprises only Type 2 income.

Effect on the Poverty Recode Variables

More information about the effects of the Social Security amount correction on poverty can be found in the user note titled 2022 SIPP: Social Security Processing Error and Its Impact on Poverty Estimates. Updated annual and monthly poverty rates using a post-hoc correction that approximates the changes made in the updated files can be found in the tables titled Corrected Annual and Monthly SIPP Poverty Rates: 2014-2022.

Version 1.0 (Released 10/28/21)

The U.S. Census Bureau released public-use data from the 2020 Survey of Income and Program Participation (2020 SIPP). The data are available in SAS, Stata, and pipe-delimited text formats. Accompanying the data release are several supporting materials, including:

(1) An online, interactive SIPP Codebook listing all variables and their definitions
(2) An updated Users' Guide to assist data users and provide background on the survey
(3) The 2020 SIPP instrument specifications providing question wording and response categories
(4) A data dictionary PDF providing metadata for all variables in the 2020 dataset
(5) User notes describing nuances and other data issues to be aware of
(6) Crosswalks that map 2020 SIPP variables to their analogues in the 2019 SIPP, and vice versa

The SIPP provides comprehensive information about the income and program participation of individuals and households in the United States. The survey collects data and measures change for many topics, including economic well-being, family dynamics, education, assets, health insurance, child care,

[4] More information about this error is available at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2014-w4-usernotes/2014w4-tptotinc-aftotinc-ahtotinc-aftotinct2-errors.html>.
[5] More information about this error is available at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2014-usernotes/2014-w1-processing-error-fam-inc.html>.

and food security. SIPP is a longitudinal survey – following the same set of respondents over a multi-year period – allowing researchers to understand how these contexts change over time.

The 2020 SIPP faced unique data collection challenges because of the COVID-19 pandemic. Due to government restrictions, mandated stay-at-home orders, and health and safety concerns for both Census interviewers and sampled households, the 2020 SIPP switched to telephone-only interviewing in March of 2020. This led to lower-than-average unit response rates nationally for the 2020 SIPP. For additional technical documentation and more information about SIPP data quality, please visit the Technical Documentation page at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation.html>.

The 2020 SIPP data release materials are available on the SIPP website at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp.html>, as is other information about the survey and a link to download the data. Additional announcements, including notifications of version updates, will be made as necessary through the SIPP website and the SIPP email notification system. To be added to the SIPP email notification system, visit the "Contact Us" page on the SIPP website at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/contact.html>.